Over the past decade and a half, the magnificent Mehrangarh Fort in Jodhpur has served as the perfect backdrop for roots musicians from across India (particularly Rajasthan) and the world to showcase their creativity. This year is no different, with the 17th edition of the Rajasthan International Folk Festival (RIFF) offering a stage to stellar art practices to shine.

From October 16-20, over 280 artists from France, Norway, South Korea, Zimbabwe and Mauritius, as well as legends from India, will entertain audiences with genre-agnostic music, dance and other cultural performances. The festival, supported by the Mehrangarh Museum Trust, includes a lineup featuring French electronica artist Éric Mouquet, who co-founded the Grammy-winning music project Deep Forest; the Manganiyars of Marwar; Kutiyattam maestro Kapila Venu from Kerala; GABBA from Norway, who won the Spellemannprisen; singer, composer and lyricist Sona Mohapatra; and emerging Rajasthani roots music group SAZ, among others.

Over 280 artists from France, Norway, South Korea, Zimbabwe and Mauritius, besides India, will entertain audiences

"When we started the festival, it was clear that we wanted to put folk musicians at the centre of it. In all these years, while we have had national and international artists as well as a gamut of roots musicians, the Rajasthani folk artist continues to have a prominent presence at RIFF," explains festival director Divya Bhatia. "Our primary motivation is to learn, understand and implement strategies in which the festival can positively impact the livelihoods of traditional artists in Rajasthan. This can't happen overnight, it takes a long time."

As with every year, collaborations will take centre stage at Jodhpur RIFF 2024, which will present the legendary exponent of both the Sindhi sarangi and the alghoza, Mehardeen Khan Langa. He will play both the instruments, accompanied by Idu and Asin Khan Langa. Asin will also collaborate with Dilshad Khan, a classical sarangi player. "This hasn't happened in a long time. Not many people pursue the idea of making folk and classical musicians play on par with each other," says Bhatia. Also, at RIFF Rustle—the grand finale to the festival's nighttime revelries on October 19—Congolese drummer Elli Miller-Maboungu will team up with ghatam master Giridhar Udupa.

A performance by Sukanya Ramgopal, the first woman ghatam player in Carnatic music is also on the cards. She will be accompanied by her student Giridhar Udupa, a master of Carnatic percussion as well as his student Shreeharsha. "We have a lot of women artists this year. While they are custodians of several orally transmitted traditions in their communities, they do not get an opportunity to perform publicly. Also, we are keen on spotlighting women who play instruments that are not their traditional domain," shares Bhatia. The event will also host an interactive session 'Why I do what I do', featuring five women from different performing art traditions of Rajasthan—Maewa Sapera, Mamta Sapera, Prem Dangi, Hanifa Manganiyar and Kamla Bhat.

Beyond the festival, the Mehrangarh Museum Trust will work closely with Bhatia to conduct regular sessions for young musicians to learn and engage with masters. There are also conversations around setting up an instrument library to provide access to pieces that are otherwise unaffordable. "All in all, the festival attempts to engender the beginnings of an ecosystem that nourishes the traditional artists in a modern setting," concludes Bhatia. ■

-Geetika Sachdev



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cordings of Mozart, Brahms and Grieg have earned him critical acclaim.

The October 17 concert will showcase Donohoe in the dual role of conductor and soloist. The programme features Edvard Grieg's 'Holberg Suite', Benjamin Britten's 'Simple Symphony' and Edward Elgar's 'Introduction' and 'Allegro for Strings', a piece originally written for the London Symphony Orchestra. The centrepiece of the evening will be Donohoe's performance of Mozart's 'Piano Concerto No. 12 in A Major, K. 414', where his commanding technique and profound musicality will take centre stage.

As the SOI continues to gain global recognition, National Centre for Performing Arts (NCPA) chairman and SOI co-founder Khushroo N. Suntook highlights the orchestra's growing reputation: "There is evidence from the recent concerts featuring Maestro Zubin Mehta and Maestro Plácido Domingo with the SOI that we have some of the world's top talent performing at the moment. Both Mehta and Domingo expressed their satisfaction with the orchestra, which signifies that we have come of age. I am looking forward to audiences attending the upcoming concert by Peter, who is indeed a legendary figure in the piano world, particularly in the UK, where he is held in very high regard."

Donohoe's solo recital on October 18 promises to be equally compelling. The programme includes Felix Mendelssohn's 'Fantasie in F-sharp Minor', Frederic Chopin's '24 Preludes', Mozart's 'Sonata No. 6 in D Major', and Sergei Rachmaninoff's 'Variations on a Theme of Chopin'. This eclectic selection will highlight Donohoe's remarkable ability to interpret works from different periods and styles, from the Classical to the Romantic era.

Donohoe's Indian debut is poised to be a landmark cultural event, offering audiences the rare opportunity to witness a pianist of extraordinary international stature. ■

-Nikhil Sardana